



conscious bet,” says Vikamsey.

IPL franchises are now appreciating assets driven by massive fan demand. Taken together, these transactions signal a structural shift in how professional cricket teams are valued, owned, and monetised.

PRIVATE EQUITY PLAY

Unlike the initial auctions of IPL teams, which were dominated by Bollywood celebrities and Indian conglomerates, these teams have now got institutional buyers interested as well, including RedBird Capital Partners, CVC Capital Partners and now Blackstone.

RedBird Capital acquired a 15% stake in RR for roughly \$37.5 million in 2021 and exited in the recent acquisition of the team at a huge upside. Similarly, CVC Capital Partners bought the GT franchise

in 2022. The PE firm sold a majority stake to the Torrent Group last year, retaining a 33% stake.

“The institutional investors don’t buy into narrative; they buy into cash flows. They model central revenue pools, stress-test cost structures, and look for visibility on returns over a defined horizon. Thus, their willingness to pay premium valuations to invest in IPL teams is not without business log-

sure steady, almost annuity-like, cash flows, insulating franchises from the volatility of on-field performance. And the third is simple economics: scarcity. There are only so many IPL teams, and even fewer opportunities to acquire meaningful stakes in them. While T20 leagues are expanding globally, IPL franchise slots remain tightly capped, preserving their scarcity.

WITH JUST 74 MATCHES IN A TWO-MONTH SEASON, THE IPL GENERATES \$16.8 MILLION PER MATCH, AMONG THE HIGHEST GLOBALLY

ic,” an industry insider told *Business Today*.

The valuations of IPL franchises sit on three powerful levers. The first is global expansion. Teams are no longer confined to a two-month window in India; they are building multi-league portfolios across geographies, extending both brand and revenue cycles through the year.

“PE participation can accelerate professional governance, unlock under-monetised revenue streams, enable multi-team global platforms, and institutionalise capital structures, shaping the IPL’s shift from promoter-led teams to scalable sports businesses,” says Vikamsey.

The second is the strength of the underlying revenue-sharing model—central media rights and sponsorship pools that en-

GLOBAL COMPARISON

IPL is an undisputed beast, not only when it comes to cricket but also compared to other global sports leagues. At roughly \$1.2 billion annually, its broadcasting deal is smaller compared to other global leagues. However, the comparison changes when adjusted to scale.

With just 74 matches in a two-month season, IPL generates \$16.8 million per match, among the highest globally. Leagues like National Football League (NFL), National Basketball Association (NBA), and English Premier League (EPL) have decades-old histories, six-month-long seasons, and anywhere between 300 to 2,000+ matches per season. IPL’s per-match revenue is second to that of the NFL’s \$36.8 million, as per a Jefferies report.

“Because there are fewer